

DALMATIAN

by
CONRAD BISHOP

Conrad Bishop has written thirty-eight produced plays and has directed more than eighty productions. He collaborates with Elizabeth Fuller in writing and staging plays and in directing *The Independent Eye* theatre company. Their plays have received production awards from the Corporation for Public Broadcasting, American Personnel & Guidance Association, and the American Bar Association. They have been co-winners of Actors Theatre of Louisville's Great American Play contest and have received a National Endowment for the Arts Playwriting Fellowship. *Dalmatian* comes from a cycle of plays called *Families* which premiered in Lancaster, Pennsylvania, in 1980.

Production Suggestions

The realistic action of *Dalmatian* is punctuated by stylized, ritualistic moments when Mrs. Leonard stands on her chair and Kathy kneels. Deciding how best to play these important transitions is part of the challenge of preparing this play.

You can handle the telephone rings either as an actual sound effect or as a sound heard only by the characters. If you choose to go without sound effects, you need to be sure your characters really do "hear" the sound and respond to it.

Address all inquiries concerning performances, readings, or reprinting of this work *or any portion thereof* to Conrad Bishop, 502 Pleasant Hill Road, Sebastopol, CA 95472. For details, see "Part II: Securing Rights for Your Production," pages 223 to 232.

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The action of the play takes place in the present in the office of the assistant principal of a high school.

Characters:

MRS. LEONARD — age unspecified. The assistant principal.

KATHY — a high school student.

Setting: *Mrs. Leonard's office is furnished with her desk and chair, a chair for the students she deals with, and a desk telephone.*

AT RISE: MRS. LEONARD, a trim woman in a business suit, sits at a desk, talking on the telephone.

MRS. LEONARD: Yes, well I'm sorry, Mrs. Bennett, but we do have state guidelines. If your son hasn't attended classes for the last eight months I really doubt he's ready to graduate . . . No, Mrs. Bennett. Our guidelines require that ninth graders be reading at least at sixth grade level and our seniors at least at the third. We have to minimize slippage. (*KATHY, a student, appears.*) Come in. Just a minute. (*On phone*) Then I suggest you call the principal and tell him what you think of me. (*Hangs up.*) What can I do for you? (*Reflex: MRS. LEONARD stands on her chair. KATHY kneels, covers head with schoolbooks.*)

KATHY: Miss Henderson sent me.

MRS. LEONARD: Oh. Kathy. Have a seat. (*She sits. KATHY sits in chair opposite.*) Now let's see. You were here once before. Mr. Bilsing . . .

KATHY: Mr. Bilsing doesn't like me.

MRS. LEONARD: "Disturbing the class."

KATHY: He got real snotty and I started to cry, and he said that disturbed the class.

MRS. LEONARD: Well, now it's Miss Henderson. (*Phone*

rings.) Excuse me. *(Answers)* No, I can't take a call now Phyllis, I've got a student. Who is it, a parent? . . . That's ridiculous. There is no drug problem at this school. Her daughter should have absolutely no problem getting any drug she wants. *(Hangs up.)* What can I do for you? *(Reflex: she stands on chair, KATHY kneels.)*

KATHY: Miss Henderson sent me.

MRS. LEONARD: Oh, Kathy. Have a seat. *(They sit.)* Now what is this? It says you were arguing with your teacher in a loud, abusive tone of voice.

KATHY: She was arguing with me.

MRS. LEONARD: About a poem.

KATHY: We had to write a poem. It said, "Write a poem based on a past experience in your life with deep emotional content using the rhyme scheme A-B-A-B."

MRS. LEONARD: So?

KATHY: So I wrote the stupid poem. And she gave me an F.

MRS. LEONARD: Well, Kathy, perhaps if you'd read the instructions more carefully . . .

KATHY: So I ask her, "Why did I get an F, because it all rhymes, I mean." And she says, "Kathy, I cannot pass you on this because you obviously did not write the poem."

MRS. LEONARD: Well, that's a very serious accusation . . .

KATHY: She says, "You are a C student and this is an A poem. And I know you copied it because I remember reading it somewhere." And I said, "I did, I did write it, and I didn't even babysit on Friday, and I had a lot of trouble rhyming some of the words, like 'dalmatian.' "

MRS. LEONARD: Dalmatian?

KATHY: We had a dalmatian.

MRS. LEONARD: So?

KATHY: When my mom and dad broke up, they had this big fight about who got the dog, and finally my dad says, "I'll take the dog, you can have the kid." Dog was a dalmatian.

(Phone rings.)

MRS. LEONARD: Excuse me. *(Answers.)* Phyllis, I said no

calls. A what? A bomb threat? They want the principal. I am the assistant principal, as you know. I handle discipline, counseling, attendance, food service, materials, and absurdity. The principal handles fire drills. Bomb threats come under fire drills. *(Hangs up.)* What is it? *(Reflex: she stands on chair, KATHY kneels.)*

KATHY: I'm Kathy-have-a-seat.

MRS. LEONARD: Oh yes. Have a seat. *(They sit.)* Kathy, my concern with you in this office is that you were arguing with the teacher. Now if your interest is poetry . . .

KATHY: I don't know that stuff. Last thing was on haiku. I got a C on that one.

MRS. LEONARD: Then you can find a time when she could sit down with you and tell you everything you want to know about poetry. She is a very good teacher, she can help you write good poems, and it's a good way of expressing yourself. Hollering at people is not a good way of expressing yourself. *(Phone rings.)* Hello! Yes! No! No! Yes! Yes! No! OK! Bye! *(Hangs up. Reflex: she starts to stand, halts, sits. Deep breath.)* Now Kathy. I'm sure that Miss Henderson has certainly read a great many poems, and she would certainly be qualified to know . . .

KATHY: And she said it was good. I wrote a good poem.

MRS. LEONARD: Kathy, you know it is possible that at one time you yourself read this poem somewhere . . .

KATHY: I don't read poems!

MRS. LEONARD: And then you forgot it, and when you were writing, it re-emerged from your subconscious.

KATHY: Huh?

MRS. LEONARD: It was in your subconscious.

KATHY: No, but we're Catholic.

MRS. LEONARD: I mean you didn't realize it, but the poem had already been written, so in a sense you were correct and Miss Henderson was also correct . . .

KATHY: When my dad left, he took the dalmatian. Two days later he came back, and I thought he was coming back

home, but he came back for the Alpo™.

MRS. LEONARD: I don't care about the Alpo™.

KATHY: It's in the poem. Does everybody's dad come back for the Alpo™?

MRS. LEONARD: All right, but your scores . . . Your test scores are below average in Verbal Synthesis. Not that we're trying to classify you . . .

KATHY: You *are* classifying me! Isn't it classifying me if I never wrote a poem before and now I write one and you classify that I can't?

MRS. LEONARD: We don't classify you for the sake of classifying you. We classify you so that we have more time to devote to your best interests.

KATHY: My best interests is that I wrote it. *I wrote it, I wrote it, I wrote it!* (MRS. LEONARD stands on chair. KATHY kneels, submissively. Silence.) I really did. (They return slowly to sitting positions.)

MRS. LEONARD: (Speaks distractedly, by rote.) Kathy, the issue is not the poem. The issue is cooperation. The poem is not for the sake of the poem. The poem is to give you experience in cooperation . . . fulfilling assignments . . . following directions . . . (Silence. She sits, covering her eyes.)

KATHY: Mrs. Leonard?

MRS. LEONARD: Does any of this . . . make any sense?

KATHY: Uh-uh.

MRS. LEONARD: (Quietly, without moving.) When I first came to work here . . . there was a bell that rang at ten-thirty. Now that wasn't for classes to change. Nothing happened at ten-thirty, except that the bell rang. So I asked, "Why does that bell ring at ten-thirty?" And I was told that it was the Ten-thirty Bell. And that we had always had a Ten-thirty Bell. And that it was not my position to question the Ten-thirty Bell. It took me some time to get used to the fact that we had . . . a Ten-thirty Bell. I used to get very upset every morning about ten-twenty-five.

Scripts for Two Actors

But I came to see at last that it did have a function. It brought us together. It rang, and we all knew we were part of something . . . that nobody understood, nobody knew the purpose, nobody could possibly change . . . but we were *all in it together*. Do you follow me? I understand your problem, I sympathize . . .

KATHY: Then will you tell Miss Henderson to give me a grade? Cause I wrote it, and she says it's good . . .

MRS. LEONARD: No, I will not. Don't you understand? Are you so stuck in your own little pimply problems that you don't think about mine? We have teacher strikes, assaults on teachers, disrespect for teachers, and I am not about to interfere with the best judgment of a teacher because a C-minus student wrote a poem! What about my needs? Who is filling my needs? Where are my strokes? Where are my warm fuzzies? *(Phone rings.) Hello!*

KATHY: I don't need an A . . . just anything.

MRS. LEONARD: *(Change of tone.)* Oh honey, hi. Are you all right? What are you doing out of bed? If you're sick, you stay in bed, otherwise you go to school. I told you not to call unless it's an emergency. What's wrong? . . . I don't know if there's peanut butter. You're nine years old, you can look. Honey, I'm busy . . . What? The mailman came? Is there a letter? Connecticut? Can you read it? What do they say? . . . How many applicants? . . . Rats. No, Mommy thought she had a chance. No, we'll stay here another year. OK, I'll be home at four. You get back in bed. Love you. *(Laughs)* OK. Bye. *(Hangs up.)* My little girl said, "My orange juice tastes angry." A child's view of the world is something very precious. *(Silence. KATHY walks out. MRS. LEONARD picks up the phone.)* Phyllis, will you take my calls? I need a potty break.

THE END